

Testing Plan — Dynamic Stack System

Last updated: 2026-05-18. Updated by Claude at end of each session.

How to use this document: After each playtest, read the decision tree on the next page to find which stack to run next. Pick the stack that addresses the most pressing issue the playtest surfaced. PDFs for all available tests are in their stack folder.

Testing Stacks

A **stack** = a group of 1–3 test scenarios that all push toward the same experience outcome. Stacks are independent — run them in any order based on what the game needs most.

Stack	Outcome	Scenarios in Stack	Status
A	Make cleverness rewarding	L2-G1: At-tack nerf · L2-G2: Combo bonus	G1 confirmed (P3) · G2 ready (pending pre-work)
B	Make Guards matter more	L3: Body-guard fix (defender-only)	De-prioritised — may be obsolete after P3
C	Shorten games / accelerate kills	King Lifetime HP · Armor Decay	Not yet written
D	Optimise board feel and scale	8×10 board (new — OQ-52) · 8×8 · Piece count · Hex grid (gated on research)	Not yet written
E	Improve drafting experience	Pool draft (OQ-35) · Placement order (OQ-36+48)	Not yet written
F	More levers for clever plays	Cascade trigger · Pin/Threatened · Sente skills (10 candidates staged)	Not yet written — gated on OQ-52/53 brainstorm
G	Radical structure redesign	Unified AP framework (no separate Movement/Action phases)	Draft written — not yet tested

Stacks Ready to Print Now

File	Contents	Stack
stack-a-cleverness/stack-a-game1-attack-nerf.pdf	Standard attack 1 DMG. Play FIRST.	A
stack-a-cleverness/stack-a-game2-attack-nerf-combo.pdf	Same + multi-Champion combo bonus. Play SECOND.	A
stack-a-cleverness/stack-a-feedback.pdf	Feedback form — fill out after both Stack A games.	A
stack-b-guards/stack-b-bodyguard-fix.pdf	Bodyguard adjacency: defender only.	B
stack-b-guards/stack-b-feedback.pdf	Feedback form — fill out after Stack B.	B
shared/game-tracking.pdf	Per-player in-game tracking sheet. Print 1 per player per game.	—

Entry Conditions Per Stack

Stack	When to enter
A	Always first — foundation for all other stacks. Results drive most downstream decisions.
B	Any time. Independent of Stack A combat results. Run whenever Guard utility feels low.
C	If first Champion kill still past Round 20 after Stack A. Two candidates: King Lifetime HP (unkillable-King) and Armor Decay (infinite-cycling). Independent of Stack B.
D	If Stack A + B data shows board size or piece density as bottleneck. Hex variant gated on running /research hex vs square grid first.
E	After Stack B (Layer 3) is accepted. Independent of combat system.
F	After Stack A combo bonus data. Dependent on combo ceiling AND standoff persistence. Gated on Stack A/B combat balance confirmation.
G	After Stacks A, B, and C stabilise. Radical change — do not test alongside other active experiments.

Current Priority Sequence

Result-driven — this ordering updates after each playtest. Last confirmed: Session 15 (2026-05-18, post-Playtest 3).

Priority	Action	Trigger to advance
P1	Pre-Stack-A-G2 prep: rule clarifications (Lance Thrust + Injured, Focus Strike + adjacent self), tracking-sheet fixes (add Standard Attack count, bake Rune scaling), update ruleset-baseline.typ to 1 DMG canonical	Baseline + tracking sheet ready
P2	Brainstorm OQ-52 (centre attractor) + OQ-53 (King as real target) — combined session	Solution candidates staged or scoped
P3	Decide combo-bonus scope (Strike+Strike-only vs cross-category) — blocks Stack A G2 rule sheet	Decision documented
P4	Run Stack A Game 2 with two experienced players	P1+P2+P3 done
P5	Evaluate Stack A G2 → choose next stack via decision tree	G2 data in hand
P6	Skill balance monitoring (Rune Theft Mode A/B, Shadow Shift, Blade Call)	Ongoing during P4–P5

After P3: the decision tree on the next page determines which of Stacks C, D, E, F, or G is next. There is no fixed ordering beyond this point — it depends on playtest results.

Decision Tree

After each playtest, follow the branch that matches your result to find the highest-value next stack.

Phase 1: Stack A + B Evaluation

After	Result	Meaning	Next
Stack A	Champion kill before R15	Combo ceiling raised — attack nerf + bonus working	Check standoff ↓
	Champion kill R15–R20	Partial improvement — monitor	Check standoff ↓
	Champion kill after R20	Pacing problem confirmed — kills too slow	→ Stack C
Standoff?	Yes — standoff persists	Players still won't commit forward	→ Stack F
	No — engagement healthy	Attack nerf dissolved the gap	→ Stack B
Stack B	Bodyguard triggers ≥ 3	Stack B accepted — Guards are useful screens	Evaluate A+B ↓
	Bodyguard triggers 1–2	Partial — consider attacker-only variant	Evaluate A+B ↓
	Bodyguard triggers 0	Still broken — investigate root cause	Evaluate A+B ↓
A+B done	Kill still past R20	Game too long despite combo bonus	→ Stack C
	Combo ceiling still low	Skills still don't feel dominant	→ Stack F
	Board feels cramped/empty	Spatial problems surfaced	→ Stack D
	Draft feels stale	Not enough variety/agency in draft	→ Stack E
	Core stable — no urgent issues	Ready for radical structure test	→ Stack G

Phase 2: Stack C → G Evaluation

After	Result	Meaning	Next
Stack C	Game ends under R25	Pacing solved	→ next issue below
(Pacing)	Game still R25+	Board size / piece count is the problem	→ Stack D
Stack F	Standoff dissolved + clever plays rewarded	Skill variety working	→ next issue below
(Cleverness II)	Partially — some improvement	Need more sente skills	Iterate in F
	No — standoff persists	Deploy fallback: midline bonus or generators	→ next issue below
Stack D	Board feel improved	Accept new board config	→ next issue below
(Board)	Tradeoffs / not improved	Try other variant (hex, piece count)	Iterate in D
Stack E	Draft experience improved	Accept draft change	→ Stack G
(Draft)	Not improved	Iterate within E	Iterate in E
Stack G	AP system is an improvement	Accept — becomes new baseline	Done
(Structure)	AP system not better	Keep current two-phase turn structure	Done

“Next issue” routing after any stack:

- Kill timing still past R20 → **Stack C**
- Combo ceiling / standoff → **Stack F**
- Board cramped → **Stack D**
- Draft stale → **Stack E**
- Core stable → **Stack G**

Session 15 context (2026-05-18): Playtest 3 confirmed Stack A Game 1 (standard attack 1 DMG) — accepted into baseline. Bodyguard activated organically without Stack B’s adjacency fix → Stack B de-prioritised. Two new OQs raised: OQ-52 (centre-of-board has no attractor, flank-drift problem) and OQ-53 (attrition vs regicide — King is incidental, not a target). These are gating Stack F. Stack D gained 8×10 narrower board as a new candidate.

Session 11 context (2026-04-29): Checkmate win condition killed — King Lifetime HP replaces it as Stack C’s lead mechanic. Sente skill design chosen as primary standoff solution (affects Stack F). 10 skill candidates staged in docs/backpocket.md . G8 guardrail added: “Players must always want to do more than they can execute.” All future stack evaluations should check G8 compliance.

Accepted Layers (Carry Forward Into All Future Sheets)

Layer	Status	What it adds
1: Economy fix	Accepted (Playtest 2, 24.04.2026)	6 start Runes · +2/turn · +1 every 5 rounds
Standard Attack 1 DMG	Accepted (Playtest 3, 17.05.2026)	Standard attack deals 1 DMG (was 2). Skills become primary damage source. Standoff dissolved.

All future layers must include Layer 1 economy values. Use section-setup(start-runes: 6, layer1-accepted: true) and section-resource-economy(start-runes: 6, layer1-accepted: true) in baseline-sections.typ.

How to Create a New Test Layer

1. Identify which stack the new layer belongs to.

2. Create folder: `docs/test-scenarios/layer-N-<stack-slug>/`
3. Write `layer-N-<desc>.typ` — import `baseline-sections.typ`, call section functions with only the changed parameters.
4. Write `layer-N-feedback.typ` — copy `shared/feedback-baseline.typ`, fill `[LAYER: ...]` placeholders, add OQ-monitoring questions for this layer's active OQs.
5. Add both files to `build-pdfs.sh`.
6. Update this TESTING_PLAN.typ: add the new scenario to the stack table, entry conditions, and decision tree.
7. Run `zsh docs/test-scenarios/build-pdfs.sh` to compile.